Research Statement

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This statement outlines my research agenda, recent papers, and future plans since beginning my position at the Pratt Institute School of Information in Fall 2024.

Research Agenda

I am a language scholar that uses digital tools to study language related to gender, sex, and sexuality. While my formal training is in English literature, with focuses in queer studies and the digital humanities (DH), I work at the intersection of the humanities and computer science (CS) disciplines, and aim my research toward audiences in AI ethics, computational linguistics, queer studies, trans studies, and DH-related fields.

To that end, I pursue a research agenda based on three main goals:

1. to interrogate the contradictions of present-day theorizations of gender, sex, and sexuality;
2. to read computational mechanisms and their effect on language meaning; and
3. to communicate to audiences across humanities and CS disciplines.

From Fall 2024 to Fall 2026, I have written five papers, two published in peer-reviewed venues, and three currently under peer review. In addition, I am also completing a manuscript for an academic book, which is expected to be published in late 2027 or early 2028.

In what follows, I explain the details of my research work and how they fit into the goals described above.

Goal #1: to interrogate the contradictions of present-day theorizations of gender, sex, and sexuality

Over the past decade, the discourse around gender, sex, and sexuality has been highly polarized around positions like the "anti-gender movement," "gender-critical feminism" and "Trans Exclusionary Radical Feminism" (TERFism), which have moved into the mainstream.[1] These largely reactionary movements are driven by resistance against "gender ideology" and, in response, seek to define gender in the "the biological reality of sex."[2]

I approach these contemporary discourses on gender, sex, and sexuality from an information studies perspective—specifically, with interest in how categories and representations, which are encoded into language forms, can thus be decoded through computational methods. Taking these contemporary discourses on gender, sex, and sexuality as a starting

[1] Bassi, Serena; LaFleur, Greta (2022). "Introduction: TERFs, Gender-Critical Movements, and Postfascist Feminisms". Transgender Studies Quarterly. 9 (3): 311–333. https://doi.org/10.1215/23289252-9836008

[2] The White House. "Defending Women From Gender Ideology Extremism And Restoring Biological Truth To The Federal Government." The White House, January 21, 2025.

point, my research interrogates and disentangles some of the contradictions that constitute social and cultural understanding of these terms through computational analysis.

In two recent papers, both of which are currently being considered at peer-reviewed venues, I explore how trans studies theorizing of gender as an expressive, material, and behavioral phenomenon opens a potential site of alignment between ideological perspectives on gender. The first paper, "What LLMs Can't See About Gender," currently under review for a CS conference, discusses the topic of gender bias in Large Language Model (LLM) evaluation methods. This method draws from recent theorizing in trans studies to show how current methods in language modeling limit the ability to detect, or *see*, gender as an identity that operates visibly in the world. The second paper, "'My Body Feels Like it's Coming Off': on Cis Embodiment in *Love Is Blind*," currently under review at a trans studies journal, reads experiences of bodily dissonance in a reality TV dating show that features cisgender and heterosexual participants. The paper argues that, despite their dramatically different self-identifications and life experiences, trans and cis-hetero subjects have similar experiences in how they relate to their own bodies—a similarity that opens a potential common ground between initially opposed perspectives.

Goal #2: to read computational mechanisms and their effect on language meaning

My book, *Queer Code: Re-working Language Technologies*, which is under contract with Bloomsbury Academic Press, explores how language technologies, like web scraping and generative AI, reduce language complexity to make it manageable and computable at large scales. These increasingly automated processes encode dominant logics and extractive incentives onto language data, resulting in technologies that perpetuate pre-determined and/or majoritarian meanings into language forms, resulting in well-documented issues such as social discrimination, as current AI tools demonstrate.

The book demonstrates how to re-work technological processes that constrain or reduce language meaning by looking to queer studies concepts that resist oppressive structures from within. Drawing from concepts like Judith Butler's Gender Performativity, for example, the book re-works constraining computational mechanisms into new analytical methodologies that open up novel readings of language data. The table below maps each chapter topic to the technology under analysis and relevant analytic from queer studies.

Chapter Title	Technology	Queer Studies Concept
1. Text Capture	Web Scraping	Paranoid Reading[3]
2. Text Analysis	Text Analysis	Gender Performativity[4]
3. Text Preservation	Markup Languages	Disidentification[5]
4. Text Display	Screen Display and Animation	The Flesh[6]
5. Text Generation	Machine Learning	Body Dysphoria[7]

[3]Sedgwick, Eve Kosofsky. "Paranoid Reading and Reparative Reading; or, you're so Paranoid, you Probably Think this Introduction is about you." *Novel Gazing: Queer Readings in Fiction* (1997): 1-37.

[4]Butler, Judith. *Bodies That Matter: on the Discursive Limits of Sex*. Routledge, 2011.

[5]Muñoz, José Esteban. *Disidentifications: Queers of Color and the Performance of Politics*. Vol. 2. U of Minnesota Press, 2013.

[6]Spillers, Hortense J. "Mama's Baby, Papa's Maybe: An American Grammar Book." *Diacritics* 17, no. 2 (1987): 65-81.

[7]Prosser, Jay. *Second Skins: The Body Narratives of Transsexuality*. Columbia University Press,

Goal #3: communicating to audiences across humanities and CS disciplines

My research aims to engage knowledges that otherwise may not come into contact with one another. Over the past two years, I have written papers for fields like computational linguistics, AI ethics, trans studies, and digital scholarly editing, which span humanities and CS disciplines.

My CS papers include "Some Myths About Bias: A Queer Studies Reading Of Gender Bias In NLP," published in the *Association for Computational Linguistics Proceedings* in August 2025, as well as "Small Language Models and the Synthetic Middle," currently under review at a CS conference, and the aforementioned "What LLMs Can't See About Gender," also under review at a CS conference. These papers draw from theorizing in queer studies and trans studies in order to make recommendations to CS fields. "Some Myths About Bias" argues that queer studies theorizing on the binary reveals certain traps of "binary thinking" that drive bias detection and mitigation techniques in Natural Language Processing (NLP). The other paper, "Small Language Models and the Synthetic Middle," incorporates the humanistic method of close reading into a computational experiment to study linguistic overlaps (the "synthetic middle") between polarized discourses on transgender rights in the USA.

On the side of the humanities, my papers include "Re-encoding Dominance: Queer Approaches To TEI Markup," published in *Digital Editing & Publishing in the 21st Century* in April 2025. This paper examines a language technology, TEI (Text Encoding Initiative), a markup standard for encoding text-based cultural heritage materials into preservable formats, alongside theories from queer studies. Much like my work in the *Queer Code* book, the goal of this paper is to read how language meaning is determined by technical mechanisms—in this case, that data formats disambiguate data into modular components (TEI "tags") in ways that delimit what can be said.

Future Plans

My most immediate plan is to continue my work on the *Queer Code* book, which is due in manuscript on March 31, 2027.

While the thinking and argumentation in this book was birthed in a literary studies context (drawing in part from my doctoral dissertation), it has also led me more firmly into the analysis of contemporary and popular discourses, such as popular journalism and reality TV. My interest in this new area, which begun with the goal of parsing out ideological investments and contradictions among gender terms, has revealed unexpected sites of overlap and consensus, which I want to pursue in a more sustained way.

After *Queer Code*, then, I plan to explore the issue of ideological polarization around gender in a subsequent book devoted primarily to that topic. I would apply literary and queer studies training toward analyzing these ideologically-encoded discourses that only seem to intensify as their content proliferates in information networks.

In the meantime, however, it is also important to my values as a scholar that I continue to make this research legible across disciplines and fields. In light of that, I will continue

1998. Prosser, Jay.

to publish in CS and humanities venues, rather than committing to one or the other, with the goal of publishing one peer-reviewed article in each of these areas per year. In doing so, I will continue to make the results of my research legible to scholars across these disciplines.